

WHAT THEY CALLED RECOVERY

Post-Audit Edit Roadmap

Chapters 1-46 | Continuity, canon, manuscript-cleanliness and final polish

CONTROL DOCUMENT

Purpose

Implement the full-manuscript audit corrections without reopening the novel structurally. The manuscript remains the primary source; working notes and roadmaps are editorial references only. Changes are applied in controlled passes, with continuity re-checked after every material correction.

Version 1.0 - 13 August 2026

1. Scope and editing rules

- Primary text: only files inside the Manuscript subfolder are treated as novel text.
- Secondary references: working notes and roadmaps may clarify intent but must not override manuscript canon silently.
- No broad rewrite: the audit found the story architecture, character arcs, conspiracy logic and ending fundamentally sound.
- Fix hard defects before style: continuity, chronology, object-state and manuscript-meta errors take priority over prose polish.
- Contextual edits only: propagated errors such as the eleven-year chronology must not be corrected with blind find-and-replace.
- Preserve successful beats: where a physical detail is wrong but the scene works, repair the action without removing the scene, humour or emotional function.
- After each phase, run a continuity check before proceeding to the next phase.

Core principle

Correct the manuscript surgically. Do not solve local defects by inventing new canon, equipment, events or backstory unless the existing manuscript requires it.

2. Locked audit findings

Chapter(s)	Issue	Required treatment	Priority
33-46	Eleven-year chronology contradiction	Reconcile Zoe age 13 with the age-8 viewing/placement history. Treat approximately five years as the working chronology unless a chapter-specific context requires different wording. Rewrite each occurrence contextually.	CRITICAL
27, 32, 33, 34, 39	Chapter/meta-manuscript language	Remove references such as "Chapter 31 taught her..." and replace them with in-world event, memory or evidence references.	CRITICAL
31	Unsupported "second screen"	Remove the nonexistent second display. Preserve the beat that Zoe closes the laptop and Elias immediately respects the boundary.	HIGH
38	Rejected dryer coin action	Replace jumper-sleeve rubbing with the familiar hard rub of the coin face against a flat hard surface, then retry. Preserve the science/superstition exchange.	MEDIUM

Chapter(s)	Issue	Required treatment	Priority
40-41	Jackie sibling wording	Correct plural "brothers" to the established canon: one brother and two sisters.	MEDIUM
24	"After two weeks" timing	Use wording consistent with elapsed chronology, e.g. "after more than two weeks" or equivalent.	LOW-MED
28	"For years they monitor me"	Correct tense if not deliberately clipped: "For years they monitored me."	LOW

3. Phase 1 - Canon and chronology lock

Objective: remove the only propagated canon defect before touching local prose. This phase governs every later edit.

3.1 Zoe / Helen / Brian duration

1. Build a chapter-by-chapter register of every "eleven years" statement from Chapter 33 onward, including dialogue, narration, payment duration and emotional references.
2. Anchor fixed facts: Zoe is thirteen in the present; the original viewing/selection material presents her at approximately eight; the family relationship therefore spans roughly five years, subject to birthday precision.
3. Rewrite each occurrence according to what the sentence actually means. Do not globally substitute "five" for "eleven".
4. Where the duration concerns payments, verify that the payment schedule remains internally plausible after the wording change.
5. Where the duration concerns Helen and Brian raising Zoe, preserve the emotional force: the relationship is real and formative even though its origin was wrong.
6. Re-read Chapters 33-46 continuously after changes to ensure no later line still assumes an eleven-year history.

Pass gate

No chapter may simultaneously preserve Zoe as thirteen, place the viewing at approximately eight, and state an eleven-year Helen/Brian history. All duration references must agree with the same chronology.

3.2 Chronology precision sweep

- Re-check day markers, "two weeks" / "more than two weeks" references, travel durations, injury recovery and major evidence milestones.
- Correct only statements that materially conflict with the established calendar; do not over-specify dates where the novel intentionally remains naturalistic.

4. Phase 2 - Remove manuscript-meta contamination

Objective: eliminate language that refers to the book as a book rather than to events inside Zoe and Elias' world.

Chapter	Flagged form	Replacement direction
27	"The rule from Chapter 24..."	Refer to the rule Zoe wrote when they first opened/worked on the drive.
32	"Something from Chapter 31 returned."	Name or evoke the earlier profile/discovery rather than the chapter number.
33	"Chapter 31 had taught her enough..."	Refer to what the recipient profile or earlier evidence had taught her.
34	"She thought about Chapter 30."	Replace with the specific earlier event, file or discovery being remembered.
34	"...spent most of a chapter of her life..."	Rewrite as ordinary lived-time language; avoid a self-conscious chapter metaphor here.
39	"Chapter 33 had taught her something."	Refer to the Helen/Brian household file or the lesson it produced.
39	"Chapter 39 had answered enough."	Replace with an in-world statement about what the evidence/investigation had answered.

Pass gate

A first-time reader should never encounter language that assumes awareness of chapter numbering, drafting order, editorial rules or the manuscript-development process.

5. Phase 3 - Local continuity and physical-realism corrections

5.1 Chapter 31 - second screen

- Confirm the computer-shop inventory: one refurbished laptop/display; no second monitor is introduced.
- Remove "second screen" rather than retroactively purchasing or introducing another monitor.
- Preserve the dramatic function: Zoe ends the viewing; Elias complies immediately and does not push her.

5.2 Chapter 38 - tumble-dryer coin

- Keep the rejected-coin beat and the science/superstition joke.
- Change Zoe's action from rubbing the coin on her jumper sleeve to pressing a flat face of the coin against a hard flat surface - naturally the metal front/panel of the machine or nearby hard plaque - and rubbing it firmly before reinsertion.

- Do not add a technical explanation of coin-validator physics unless the scene independently needs one; the recognisable human ritual is enough.

5.3 Jackie sibling canon

- Established canon: Jackie is eldest of four - Jackie, two sisters and one brother.
- Correct "brothers and sisters" in Chapters 40-41 to "brother and sisters" wherever it refers to Jackie's siblings.

5.4 Minor line-level precision

- Chapter 24: adjust elapsed-time wording around carrying the drive so it matches the reconstructed chronology.
- Chapter 28: correct the monitoring sentence tense unless a deliberately fragmented voice is clearly intended.
- During these edits, record any newly noticed hard continuity issue, but do not expand the pass into general rewriting.

Pass gate

Every object, family fact and physical action introduced by these corrections must already exist in canon or be a direct, minimal repair. No fix may create a new continuity burden.

6. Phase 4 - Object and state continuity sweep

Objective: exploit the two flagged object/action defects as prompts for a final ledger check across the full manuscript.

- Computer equipment: laptop, drives, write blocker, mouse, cables, adapters and any later hardware references.
- Evidence objects: folder, original drive, working copy, protected/secondary copy and transfer states.
- Phones and operational handsets: possession, disposal, replacement, charging and who can contact whom.
- Vehicles and travel: ownership/use, swaps, abandonment and scene-to-scene movement.
- Zoe's backpack and personal possessions: what it contains, when objects are removed, and its symbolic return to ordinary use.
- Injuries and medication: Elias's ribs, pain management, movement limits and later recovery.
- Clothing and ordinary objects used as callbacks: keep only continuity-significant checks; do not police harmless wardrobe variation.

Pass gate

No object should appear without introduction, vanish when still plot-relevant, change owner without a transfer, or be described in a state incompatible with the previous scene.

7. Phase 5 - Prose and voice refinement

Objective: reduce visible repetition introduced by the readability rewrites while preserving the novel's established clipped, tense voice.

- Audit repeated constructions: "Not X. Not Y. Just Z.", "That was enough.", repeated "She looked at..." / "He looked at...", repeated negative declaratives, and three-beat fragments.

- Keep strong recurring constructions where they carry rhythm or emphasis; reduce only clusters that make the technique visible.
- Watch second-half chapter templating: new day -> investigative question -> controlled discovery/test -> interpretation -> notebook insight -> next-day transition.
- Vary transitions and chapter-end mechanics where the pattern becomes predictable, without disturbing investigative logic.
- Protect Zoe's intelligence but ensure highly analytical lines still sound like Zoe rather than an editorial framework speaking through her.
- Do not flatten Elias, Jackie, Helen/Brian, Voss or Vale into a single polished narrative voice.

Pass gate

The prose should feel like one deliberately written novel, not forty-six chapters polished in separate sessions. Voice motifs may repeat; editing fingerprints should not.

8. Phase 6 - Production consistency

- Standardise chapter-title punctuation, spacing and heading format across Chapters 1-46.
- Check scene-break symbols/spacing for consistency.
- Remove any remaining editorial residue, roadmap language, revision notes, bracketed placeholders or drafting markers.
- Check em/en dash and quotation-mark consistency according to the manuscript's established house style.
- Confirm no duplicate paragraphs, accidental repeated lines or formatting-only page artefacts remain.
- Keep file names and chapter numbers aligned with the manuscript sequence.

9. Phase 7 - Verification and cold-read audit

1. Re-run the continuity searches for all corrected terms: eleven years, chapter-number references, second screen, sibling plurals, major time expressions and equipment references.
2. Perform a sequential Chapters 1-46 read focused only on story logic and reader comprehension - no sentence polishing unless the line causes confusion.
3. Track unresolved threads and classify each as intentional future/ending resonance, resolved payoff, or accidental omission.
4. Check setup/payoff pairs, reader knowledge versus character knowledge, and whether revelations occur before the evidence that enables them.
5. Re-read Chapters 43-46 as an ending unit to ensure late corrections have not weakened agency, emotional closure or the final-direction motif.
6. Only after this cold read passes should the manuscript be treated as ready for final copy-edit/proof preparation.

Cold-read standard

Read as if none of the drafting history exists. If a line requires knowledge of our notes, earlier versions, chapter numbering or intended explanation to make sense, the manuscript has not yet passed.

10. Execution order and change-control protocol

Order	Pass	Output	Do not proceed until...
1	Canon/chronology	Corrected Ch33-46 duration references	All age/duration statements agree
2	Meta-language	All Chapter-X residue removed	No editorial/manuscript references remain
3	Local corrections	Ch24, Ch28, Ch31, Ch38, Ch40-41 repaired	All flagged hard defects are closed
4	Object/state sweep	Updated continuity ledger	No unsupported object/state transitions remain
5	Prose/voice	Targeted repetition reductions	Voice remains recognisably the same novel
6	Production	Standardised chapter presentation	Formatting and residue checks pass
7	Cold read	Final audit report / remaining issue list	No critical or high-severity issue remains

11. Final acceptance checklist

- ☐ Zoe age / viewing age / Helen-Brian duration are mutually consistent.
- ☐ No "Chapter X" or other manuscript-meta phrasing remains inside the story.
- ☐ No unsupported second monitor/display exists.
- ☐ Chapter 38 coin action matches recognisable real-world behaviour while retaining the original joke.
- ☐ Jackie's sibling count and genders remain consistent everywhere.
- ☐ Major day/week references agree with the manuscript calendar.
- ☐ Core evidence objects and copies remain distinct and traceable.
- ☐ Phones, vehicles, injuries and possessions have coherent states and transfers.
- ☐ Repetitive prose devices have been reduced selectively, not erased.
- ☐ Second-half investigative chapters no longer reveal an overly obvious repeated template.
- ☐ Chapter formatting and headings are standardised.
- ☐ Cold read produces no critical or high-severity continuity, logic or reader-confusion defect.
- ☐ Chapter 46 still lands on agency, shared decision-making and the final-direction motif without added explanation.

Completion definition

The roadmap is complete when the manuscript can be read from Chapter 1 through Chapter 46 without relying on drafting history to reconcile chronology, objects, relationships or narrative language - and without changing the successful structural design of the novel.